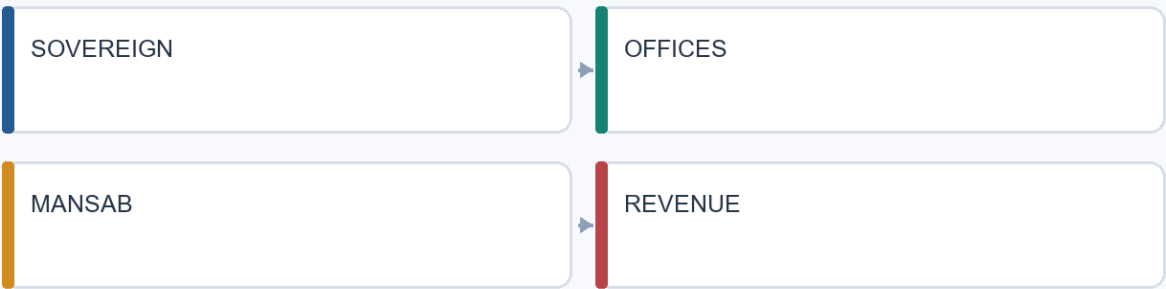


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Akbar's state: rank, record, revenue



The package is a system map: appointment, rank, verification and assessment work together.

VISUAL 01

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Verified PYQ route and solved response

2021 CSE Prelims GS-I, Q45 — Direct/owned

Exact wording verified from local paper: “With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?”

(a) Paragana-Sarkar-Suba (b) Sarkar-Paragana-Suba (c) Suba-Sarkar-Paragana (d) Paragana-Suba-Sarkar

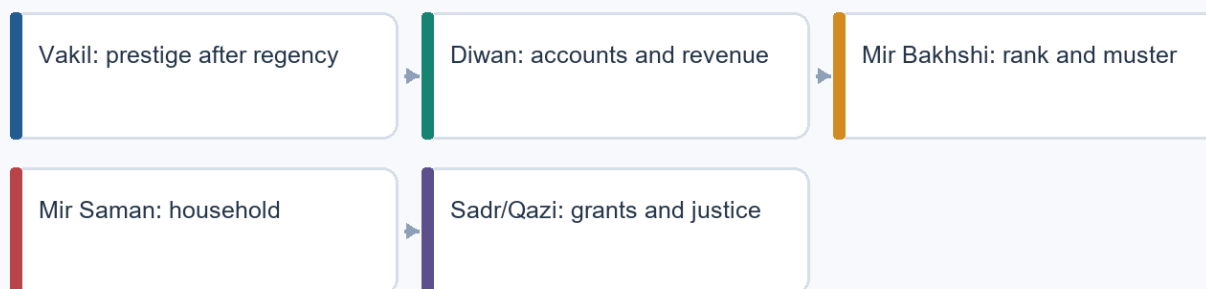
INFERRED ANSWER — NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (a), confidence high. Pargana is smaller than sarkar, and sarkar is smaller than suba. The source paper fixes wording/order but a local official key is absent. The direct concept belongs to Topic 16. The 2019 jagirdar-zamindar Prelims route remains Topic 24; do not relabel it as a direct Topic 16 PYQ.

What an excellent Prelims explanation notices: hierarchy asks territorial scale, not rank; do not substitute village administration or mansab terminology. The closest error is (b), which preserves suba at the top but reverses pargana and sarkar.

PYQ coverage transparency

Search window	Direct/adjacent result	Treatment
2018-25 CSE Prelims/GS-I routing ledgers	2021 Q45 is direct/owned	reproduced exactly; answer inferred, not official
2019 Prelims jagirdar-zamindar	adjacent, Topic 24 owner	cross-link only
2025 GS-I religious syncretism	adjacent, Topic 17 owner	cross-link only
Mansabdari/dahsala/zabt/offices searches	no additional exact direct CSE item verified locally	no fabricated PYQ

Central offices: distinct functions



Use functional labels; do not convert offices into modern ministries.

VISUAL 05

Use functional labels; do not convert offices into modern ministries.

Diwan's fiscal workflow

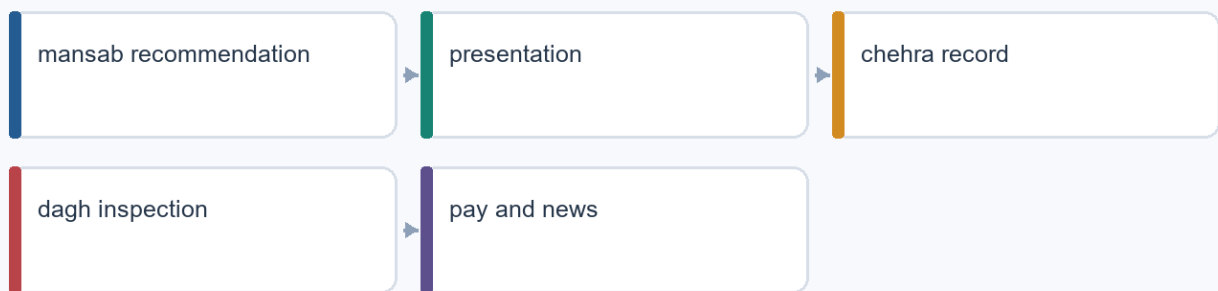


The diwan was a financial controller, not merely a collector.

VISUAL 07

The diwan was a financial controller, not merely a collector.

Mir Bakhshi: rank to muster

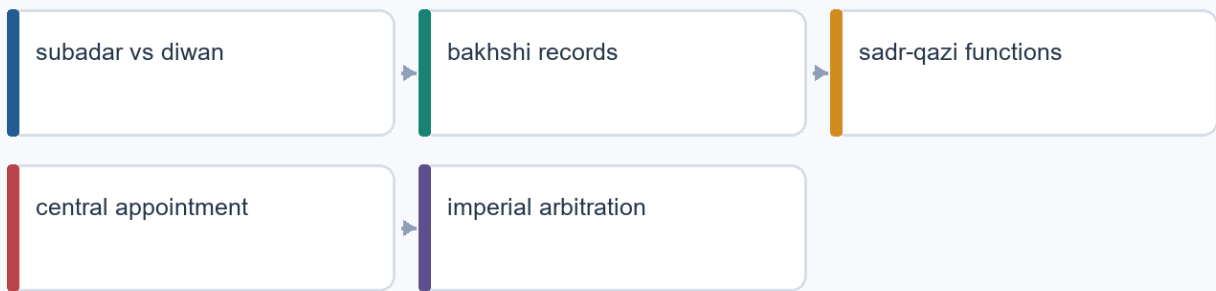


Military records and elite management were connected through the mansab.

VISUAL 08

Military records and elite management were connected through the mansab.

Checks, overlap and limits



Checks prevented concentration but did not create independent constitutional branches.

VISUAL 09

Checks prevented concentration but did not create independent constitutional branches.

Provincial replication of the centre

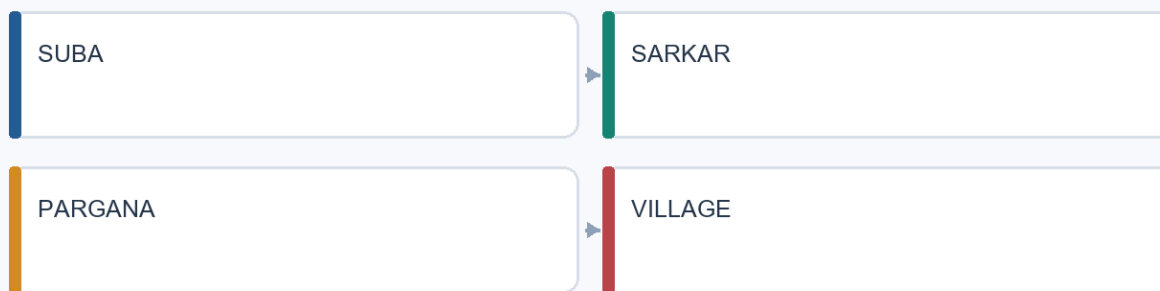


Centrally appointed officers were designed to report and counterbalance.

VISUAL 12

Centrally appointed officers were designed to report and counterbalance.

Administrative hierarchy



Ascending territorial size: pargana -> sarkar -> suba.

VISUAL 14

Ascending territorial size: pargana -> sarkar -> suba.

Khalisa, jagir and inam



Different fiscal destinations did not turn assignments into sovereign territories.

VISUAL 19

Different fiscal destinations did not turn assignments into sovereign territories.

Mansab: status, salary and service

rank

remuneration

obligation

imperial dependence

One graded service linked civil position, military duty and courtly status.

VISUAL 21

One graded service linked civil position, military duty and courtly status.

Mansab hierarchy

10 upward

graded rank

5000 high rank

7000 exceptional under Akbar

Do not imagine a fixed table unchanged throughout the reign.

VISUAL 22

Do not imagine a fixed table unchanged throughout the reign.

Zat and sawar after 1595-96

ZAT: personal status/pay

SAWAR: cavalry obligation

late distinction

not one early fixed form

A distinction in rank clarified two different dimensions of service.

VISUAL 24

A distinction in rank clarified two different dimensions of service.

Cash pay and jagir payment

cash salary possible

jagir commonly assigned

jama valuation

collection realities

A jagir was a way of meeting remuneration, not a grant of private land.

VISUAL 27

A jagir was a way of meeting remuneration, not a grant of private land.

Dagh and chehra: a continuity timeline

Alauddin: introduced/used

Sher Shah: revived/adapted

Akbar: systematised in Mughal frame

Akbar did not invent horse branding or descriptive rolls from nothing.

VISUAL 30

Akbar did not invent horse branding or descriptive rolls from nothing.

Horse and soldier verification

muster

chehra

dagh

inspection

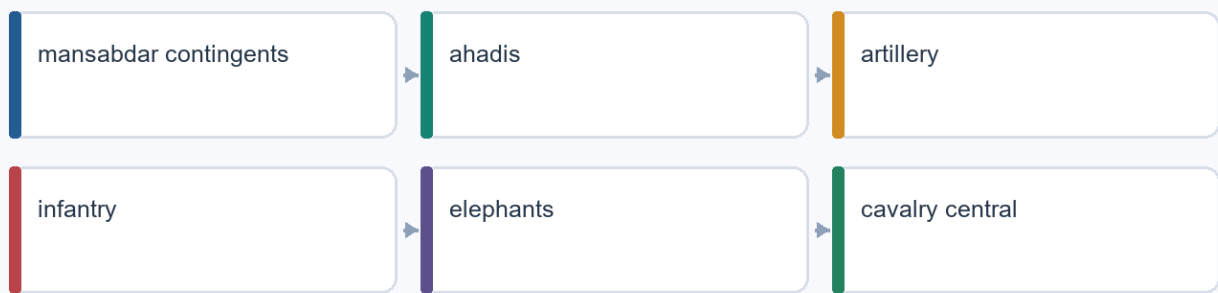
detering false claims

Controls targeted the gap between sanctioned contingents and present troops.

VISUAL 31

Controls targeted the gap between sanctioned contingents and present troops.

Imperial military composition

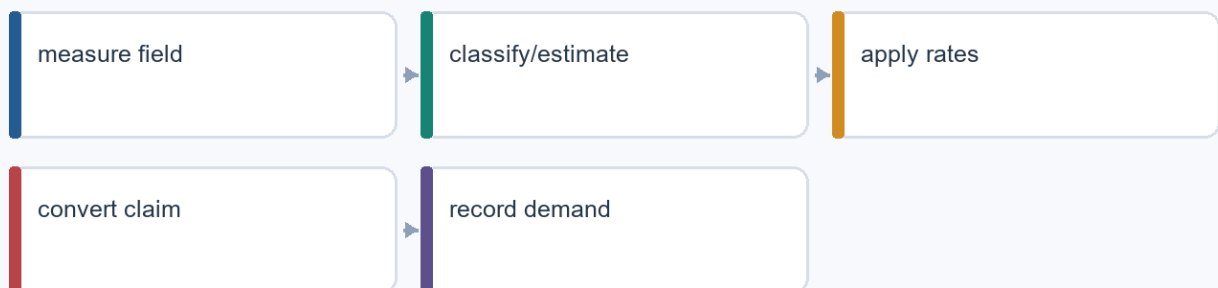


This was not a modern national standing army with a single uniform payroll.

VISUAL 33

This was not a modern national standing army with a single uniform payroll.

Zabti: measurement-based assessment

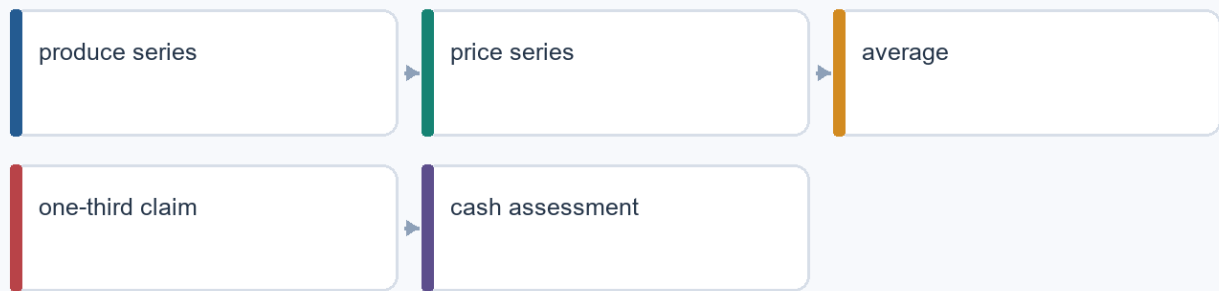


Zabti names a measurement-based mode; it is not identical to every ten-year average.

VISUAL 37

Zabti names a measurement-based mode; it is not identical to every ten-year average.

Dahsala: ten-year averaging

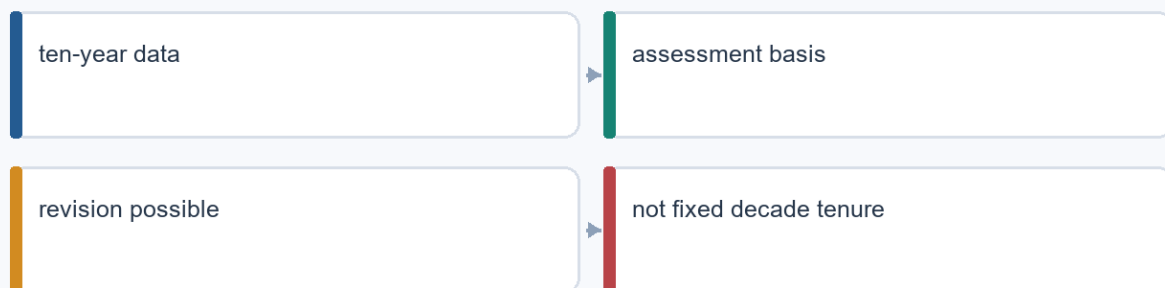


The average was a calculation for assessment, not a permanent ten-year contract.

VISUAL 39

The average was a calculation for assessment, not a permanent ten-year contract.

Dahsala is not a ten-year settlement



The word 'ten' concerns the averaging window, not immutable settlement duration.

VISUAL 40

The word 'ten' concerns the averaging window, not immutable settlement duration.

Assessment methods compared

zabt: measure and rates

batai: share crop

kankut: measurement + estimate

nasaq: prior estimate

Choice varied with crop, terrain, records and administrative reach.

VISUAL 42

Choice varied with crop, terrain, records and administrative reach.

Reach and limits of zabt/dahsala

Lahore to Allahabad

Malwa

Gujarat

difficult tracts

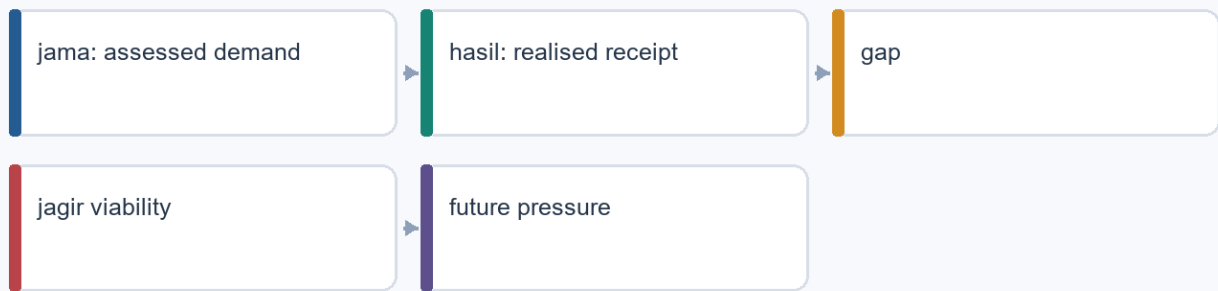
alternatives

No claim that every province, field or crop fell under one uniform procedure.

VISUAL 46

No claim that every province, field or crop fell under one uniform procedure.

Jama and hasil

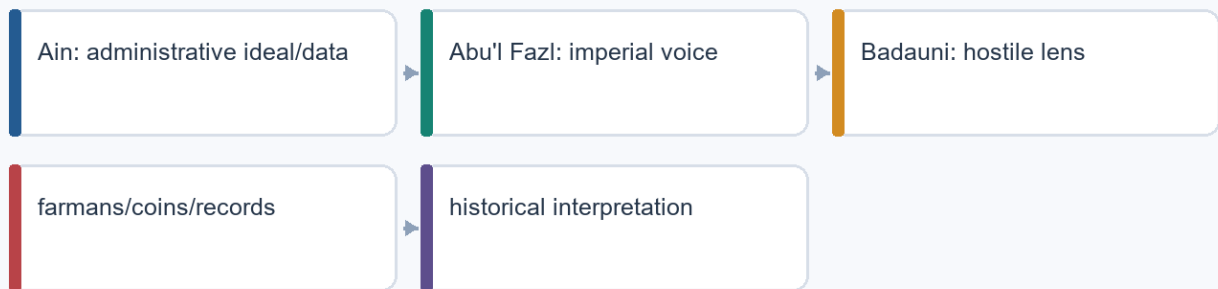


An assessed figure is not the same as cash or grain actually realised.

VISUAL 48

An assessed figure is not the same as cash or grain actually realised.

Sources and their reach

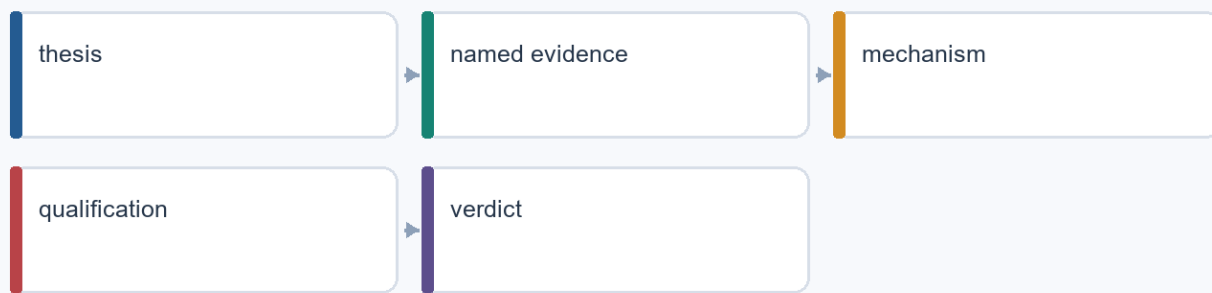


Evidence must be matched to the claim it can and cannot sustain.

VISUAL 56

Evidence must be matched to the claim it can and cannot sustain.

Mains answer spine



Use claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification rather than fact lists.

VISUAL 58

Use claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification rather than fact lists.

Learning MCQ loop — 20 questions (A -> B -> C -> D repeated five times)

Q1. Which statement best captures the relationship between zabti and dahsala?

A. Zabti is measurement-based assessment; dahsala uses ten-year produce and price averages in assessment. B. Dahsala was a permanent ten-year settlement. C. Zabti was a crop-sharing method. D. Both terms mean a hereditary revenue grant. **Answer: A — Zabti is measurement-based assessment; dahsala uses ten-year produce and price averages in assessment.** **Explanation:** The discriminator is that zabti names a measurement-based mode while dahsala names an averaging method. The closest distractor makes dahsala a fixed-tenure settlement, confusing data window with settlement duration.

Q2. The principal political lesson Akbar drew from Bairam Khan's early regency was to

A. make the diwan a hereditary office. B. prevent the wakil from becoming a permanently over-mighty centre of effective power. C. abolish all provincial governors. D. separate religion from all administration. **Answer: B — prevent the wakil from becoming a permanently over-mighty centre of effective power.** **Explanation:** The answer follows the reduced effective power of the wakil after Bairam Khan. The plausible but wrong fiscal alternative mistakes a regency lesson for a rule about the diwan.

Q3. Which officer is most closely connected with mansab recommendations, presentation and muster records?

A. Diwan B. Mir saman C. Mir bakhshi D. Sadr-us-sudur **Answer: C — Mir bakhshi** **Explanation:** Mir bakhshi is the rank-and-muster node. Diwan is the closest distractor because finance could overlap with payment, but he was not the primary officer for presentation and military record.

Q4. In Akbar's provincial design, the strongest evidence of a ruler-centred check is that

A. the subadar owned all land in the suba. B. each suba was a federal province. C. village institutions were abolished. D. provincial officers were centrally appointed and their functions were differentiated. **Answer: D — provincial officers were centrally appointed and their functions were differentiated.** **Explanation:** Central appointment plus separate functions is the check. A federal-province analogy fails because authority derived from imperial appointment, not constitutional autonomy.

Q5. The correct ascending sequence of territorial units is

A. pargana -> sarkar -> suba. B. suba -> sarkar -> pargana. C. sarkar -> pargana -> suba. D. village -> suba -> pargana. **Answer: A — pargana -> sarkar -> suba.** **Explanation:** Pargana is below sarkar and suba is larger. The closest wrong choice reverses pargana and sarkar while keeping suba at the top.

Q6. A jagir in the mansabdari context was primarily

A. a grant of absolute ownership in all village land. B. an assignment of state revenue used to meet remuneration. C. a hereditary sovereign province. D. a village panchayat treasury. **Answer: B — an assignment of state revenue used to meet remuneration.** **Explanation:** A revenue assignment is the key discriminator. The ownership distractor is tempting because revenue rights are substantial, but they are not private title.

Q7. The late distinction between zat and sawar separated

A. religious grant from judicial office. B. cash revenue from crop share. C. personal rank/status from cavalry obligation. D. a suba from a sarkar. **Answer: C — personal rank/status from cavalry obligation.** **Explanation:** Zat relates to personal status/pay and sawar to cavalry obligation. The cash/crop option is a revenue-method distinction, not a mansab distinction.

Q8. Which provenance chain for dagh and chehra is safest?

A. Akbar invented both without precedent. B. Sher Shah abolished them before Akbar. C. They were a British innovation. D. Alauddin Khalji introduced/used them; Sher Shah revived/adapted; Akbar systematised them in a Mughal framework. **Answer: D — Alauddin Khalji introduced/used them; Sher Shah revived/adapted; Akbar systematised them in a Mughal framework.** **Explanation:** Continuity through Alauddin, Sher Shah and Akbar is the required correction. The closest distractor erases precedent by assigning invention solely to Akbar.

Q9. The central purpose of horse branding and descriptive rolls was to

A. test claimed cavalry resources against actual horses and personnel. B. convert jagirs into property titles. C. fix village boundaries permanently. D. replace all cash payments with grain. **Answer: A — test claimed cavalry resources against actual horses and personnel.** **Explanation:** Dagh and chehra target fictitious musters and substitution. The jagir distractor imports a property issue unrelated to verification.

Q10. Which formulation best describes the imperial army under Akbar?

A. A fully national conscript army under one payroll. B. A cavalry-centred mix of mansabdar contingents, ahadis and other arms, not a modern uniform standing army. C. Only Rajput cavalry with no artillery. D. A force independent of mansab ranks. **Answer: B — A cavalry-centred mix of mansabdar contingents, ahadis and other arms, not a modern uniform standing army.** **Explanation:** The mixed composition and centrality of cavalry are the key. The modern national-army option fails because service and contingents were mediated through mansabdars.

Q11. Dahsala's ten years refer to

A. a guaranteed ten-year tenure for each cultivator. B. a ten-year ban on crop sharing. C. the averaging of produce and prices used in assessment. D. the tenure of every jagir. **Answer: C — the averaging of produce and prices used in assessment.** **Explanation:** The word 'dahsala' points to the averaging calculation. The plausible wrong option converts a fiscal technique into permanent land tenure.

Q12. The jarib described in the revenue system principally served to

A. brand cavalry horses. B. record soldiers' features. C. divide crop shares at harvest. D. measure land for assessment, with standardising devices such as bamboo linked by iron rings. **Answer: D — measure land for assessment, with standardising devices such as bamboo linked by iron rings.** **Explanation:** Jarib is a measuring instrument. Horse branding and descriptive roll are deliberately close technical distractors from the military system.

Q13. Polaj, parati/parauti, chachar and banjar are best treated as

A. categories linked to cultivation and fallow history. B. a simple hierarchy of caste status. C. the four ranks of mansabdars. D. four kinds of judicial court. **Answer: A — categories linked to cultivation and fallow history.** **Explanation:** Cultivation frequency is the discriminator. Calling them a fertility-only ladder overstates what the labels convey.

Q14. Batai or ghalla-bakhshi is

A. a ten-year price average. B. crop sharing in a fixed proportion. C. measurement plus standing-crop appraisal. D. an estimate based chiefly on past payment. **Answer: B — crop sharing in a fixed proportion.** **Explanation:** Batai is the crop-share method. Kankut is the closest distractor because it concerns crop assessment, but it combines measurement and appraisal rather than direct division.

Q15. Kankut is most accurately described as

A. a permanent cash settlement. B. a religious grant. C. measurement combined with inspection or appraisal of the standing crop. D. the separation of zat and sawar. **Answer: C — measurement combined with inspection or appraisal of the standing crop.** **Explanation:** The method combines measurement with estimate. The cash-settlement option misreads all revenue methods as zabt.

Q16. Nasaq differed from a fresh detailed zabt exercise because it relied substantially on

A. horse branding records. B. only division of harvested crop. C. the emperor's personal rank. D. previous assessment/payment and estimate. **Answer: D — previous assessment/payment and estimate.** **Explanation:** Nasaq's estimated, previous-demand logic is decisive. Crop division is batai, the closest revenue-method distractor.

Q17. The safest statement on geographic reach is that

A. zabt/dahsala had identified zones such as Lahore to Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat, while alternatives persisted elsewhere. B. dahsala covered every field in all of India. C. only Bengal used measurement. D. no revenue method operated outside Agra. **Answer: A — zabt/dahsala had identified zones such as Lahore to Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat, while alternatives persisted elsewhere.** **Explanation:** The source-bound geographic zones and uneven reach are correct. The universal-zabt claim is the intended trap.

Q18. Jama and hasil should be distinguished because

A. jama is cavalry rank whereas hasil is horse branding. B. jama is assessed demand whereas hasil is realised receipt. C. jama is a village council whereas hasil is a suba. D. both are exact synonyms for jagir. **Answer: B — jama is assessed demand whereas hasil is realised receipt.** **Explanation:** Assessment versus realisation is the fiscal distinction. Treating the terms as synonyms hides the paper-versus-receipt gap.

Q19. A zamindar is best understood as

A. simply a transferable imperial revenue assignee. B. a modern registered property owner. C. a local claimant and intermediary with social and sometimes armed power. D. the same office as mir bakhshi. **Answer: C — a local claimant and intermediary with social and sometimes armed power.** **Explanation:** Local claims and mediation distinguish zamindar from jagirdar. The transferable-assignee option is the closest because it describes the latter, not the former.

Q20. The most defensible conclusion on Akbar's checks is that

A. the emperor was constitutionally powerless. B. the system had modern judicial review. C. each office was an autonomous branch of government. D. separate offices and reports restrained concentration, but final authority remained ruler-centred. **Answer: D — separate offices and reports restrained concentration, but final authority remained ruler-centred.** **Explanation:** The answer preserves both differentiation and monarchical primacy. Autonomous-branch language is a misleading modern analogy.

Broad practice — 44 questions (A -> B -> C -> D repeated eleven times)

Q1. After Bairam Khan, the wakil most accurately retained

A. prestige without the earlier monopoly of effective regency power. B. a hereditary right to appoint all diwans. C. control over every provincial treasury. D. an independent constitutional veto. **Answer: A — prestige without the earlier monopoly of effective regency power.** **Explanation:** The post-regency change curtailed effective concentration, not the office's existence. The veto option imports constitutional language alien to the arrangement.

Q2. A diwan's scrutiny of khalisa, jagir and inam chiefly shows responsibility for

A. horse branding at muster. B. fiscal accounts and the allocation of revenue claims. C. criminal policing in every village. D. the personal rank of all qazis. **Answer: B — fiscal accounts and the allocation of revenue claims.** **Explanation:** Accounts and fiscal destinations lie in the diwan's field. Horse branding belongs to dagh, the deliberately nearby military distractor.

Q3. Why should mir bakhshi not be translated simply as 'defence minister'?

A. He had no connection with military personnel. B. He only maintained karkhanas. C. His rank, presentation, muster and record functions operated inside personal imperial authority. D. He was a village revenue officer. **Answer: C — His rank, presentation, muster and record functions operated inside personal imperial authority.** **Explanation:** The issue is anachronistic equivalence, not absence of military work. Karkhanas belong to the mir saman's field.

Q4. The mir saman/khan-i-saman is most useful in an answer on

A. judicial independence from the emperor. B. ten-year revenue averaging. C. suba boundaries. D. household, workshops, stores and material imperial capacity. **Answer: D — household, workshops, stores and material imperial capacity.** **Explanation:** Household logistics and karkhanas are the defining connection. Revenue averaging belongs to dahsala, not this office.

Q5. The cautious statement on sadr and qazi is that they

A. handled grant and judicial-religious functions within imperial political authority. B. formed a modern independent supreme court. C. were elected provincial representatives. D. replaced the diwan in fiscal audit. **Answer: A — handled grant and judicial-religious functions within imperial political authority.** **Explanation:** The functions are real but institutionally dependent. The modern-court option mistakes judicial activity for constitutional autonomy.

Q6. Which provincial arrangement most directly limited a subadar's monopoly?

A. Giving the subadar permanent ownership of jagirs. B. A provincial diwan separately handling fiscal records and accounts. C. Abolishing reporting to the centre. D. Making every village a suba. **Answer: B — A provincial diwan separately handling fiscal records and accounts.** **Explanation:** A distinct diwan created a parallel fiscal channel. Permanent ownership would intensify rather than restrain local concentration.

Q7. The 2021 hierarchy PYQ tests the fact that a pargana is

A. a rank above a mansab. B. a type of revenue grant. C. smaller than a sarkar and larger than no listed higher unit in the sequence. D. a unit above suba. **Answer: C — smaller than a sarkar and larger than no listed higher unit in the sequence.** **Explanation:** Pargana is the first ascending unit in pargana-sarkar-suba. The rank and grant choices deliberately cross technical baskets.

Q8. A safe qualification about a faujdar is that

A. he had no relation to order or force. B. he was identical with a patwari. C. he always assessed dahsala averages. D. his coercive jurisdiction was not always exactly coterminous with one sarkar. **Answer: D — his coercive jurisdiction was not always exactly coterminous with one sarkar.** **Explanation:** Variation in jurisdiction is the point. The patwari alternative confuses a local record role with a coercive office.

Q9. The qanungo is most plausibly placed in a discussion of

A. pargana-level local records and revenue knowledge. B. imperial household workshops. C. cavalry branding. D. the sovereign's daily darbar. **Answer: A — pargana-level local records and revenue knowledge.** **Explanation:** Qanungo belongs to the record cluster supporting assessment. Branding is dagh, an intentionally technical but wrong alternative.

Q10. Which actor best represents village-level fiscal mediation?

A. A mir bakhshi presenting mansabdars. B. A muqaddam/patel working amid local records and custom. C. A provincial sadr issuing grants. D. A high-zat court noble only. **Answer: B — A muqaddam/patel working amid local records and custom.** **Explanation:** Muqaddam or patel reflects local mediation. The other options operate at court or provincial scale.

Q11. Khalisa revenues were distinguished because they were

A. the private landed property of every mansabdar. B. a synonym for madad-i-maash. C. reserved for the crown rather than assigned as a jagir. D. a cavalry category. **Answer: C — reserved for the crown rather than assigned as a jagir.** **Explanation:** Crown revenue is the discriminator. A jagir is an assignment, while a madad-i-maash/inam is a different grant form.

Q12. Madad-i-maash/inam is best placed under

A. the suba-sarkar territorial ladder. B. horse and soldier verification. C. the crop-share method. D. grant arrangements, distinct from routine jagir remuneration. **Answer: D — grant arrangements, distinct from routine jagir remuneration.** **Explanation:** The terms belong to grants. Crop share describes batai, which is a revenue-assessment method rather than a grant.

Q13. Why is a mansab more than a military quota?

A. It simultaneously expressed rank, remuneration and service obligation. B. It permanently transferred land title. C. It fixed a village's crop type. D. It was only a religious donation. **Answer: A — It simultaneously expressed rank, remuneration and service obligation.** **Explanation:** The three-part service relationship is essential. Land title is the standard jagir misconception, not the meaning of mansab.

Q14. A statement that all Akbar-era ranks followed one unchanging table is weak because

A. ranks began only after 1707. B. the system developed in stages and high ranks marked changing imperial elevation. C. no rank was ever linked to pay. D. mansab applied only to peasants. **Answer: B — the system developed in stages and high ranks marked changing imperial elevation.** **Explanation:** Development over the reign is the correction. The 1707 and peasant options contradict the system's basic setting.

Q15. Composite recruitment mattered because it

A. abolished every group identity immediately. B. made all offices hereditary. C. placed varied elite backgrounds within a common imperial hierarchy of service and favour. D. removed the emperor from appointments. **Answer: C — placed varied elite backgrounds within a common imperial hierarchy of service and favour.** **Explanation:** Integration is not social erasure. The hereditary option reverses the role of imperial appointment and transfer.

Q16. The late zat-sawar division made it possible to distinguish

A. a village from a pargana. B. a crop rate from a price average. C. a qazi from a sadr. D. courtly personal standing from the cavalry resource a holder owed. **Answer: D — courtly personal standing from the cavalry resource a holder owed.** **Explanation:** The distinction is within mansab. The revenue and territorial pairs are close-sounding but belong to different systems.

Q17. An assignment based on a high jama could disappoint a mansabdar because

A. actual hasil might fall short of assessed paper demand. B. jama was a horse-branding register. C. hasil was always a rank above zat. D. jagir automatically meant ownership. **Answer: A — actual hasil might fall short of assessed paper demand.** **Explanation:** Jama versus hasil is assessment versus receipt. The closest distractor repeats the ownership error that the distinction is meant to prevent.

Q18. Transfer of jagirs most directly served the centre by

A. making every assignment hereditary. B. keeping an assignee's position dependent on imperial reassignment. C. ending all local intermediaries. D. turning provinces into federations. **Answer: B — keeping an assignee's position dependent on imperial reassignment.** **Explanation:** Transfer can curb durable local roots. Hereditary and federal alternatives reverse the logic of imperial dependence.

Q19. Akbar's 1573-74 dagh measure is most directly connected to

A. classification of fallow land. B. the appointment of a qazi. C. inspection of horses claimed for service. D. a ten-year price average. **Answer: C — inspection of horses claimed for service.** **Explanation:** Dagh is horse branding. Fallow categories and price averaging are revenue concepts placed as technical traps.

Q20. Chehra was valuable because it

A. measured a field with bamboo rings. B. assigned crown revenue to khalisa. C. converted produce into cash rates. D. made soldiers individually describable for muster-related scrutiny. **Answer: D — made soldiers individually describable for muster-related scrutiny.** **Explanation:** Descriptive rolls make personnel more legible. The jarib and cash-rate choices belong to revenue assessment.

Q21. Ahadis help qualify a statement that the army consisted only of

A. mansabdar contingents, since centrally associated elements also existed. B. revenue clerks, because ahadis were accountants. C. village councils, because ahadis were panchayats. D. crop shares, because ahadis were batai. **Answer: A — mansabdar contingents, since centrally associated elements also existed.** **Explanation:** Ahadis are relevant to imperial military composition. The other choices deliberately replace military vocabulary with civil or fiscal vocabulary.

Q22. The cautious role of news writers is to show that

A. all reports were false by definition. B. information and reports supported central oversight without proving one uniform modern intelligence service. C. the diwan ceased fiscal work. D. every village was directly ruled by mir bakhshi. **Answer: B — information and reports supported central oversight without proving one uniform modern intelligence service.** **Explanation:** Reports indicate an oversight aspiration and practice. The modern-agency claim is the close anachronistic overstatement.

Q23. Why did central price schedules create a revenue problem?

A. They made all measurements unnecessary. B. They abolished currency. C. Court-centred prices could be delayed or ill suited to local conditions. D. They turned jagirs into titles. **Answer: C — Court-centred prices could be delayed or ill suited to local conditions.** **Explanation:** Regional variation and delay are the mechanism. The other options confuse price policy with land measurement or legal title.

Q24. A statement that revenue reform was 'peasant welfare only' is inadequate because

A. peasants never cultivated under Akbar. B. revenue had no relation to records. C. only religious grants funded the empire. D. predictable assessment also served imperial finance, control and military remuneration. **Answer: D — predictable assessment also served imperial finance, control and military remuneration.** **Explanation:** Fiscal extraction and capacity are central objectives. The welfare-only claim misses why the court needed assessment.

Q25. The iron-linked bamboo jarib is evidence for

A. an effort to reduce manipulation in measurement. B. a device for listing soldiers. C. a symbol of a permanent settlement. D. a method of crop sharing. **Answer: A — an effort to reduce manipulation in measurement.** **Explanation:** Anti-stretching standardisation is the point. Soldier listing is chehra, while crop share is batai.

Q26. Dastur is most safely invoked as

A. a rank above 5000. B. a crop-rate/rate-setting element in assessment practice. C. a village judicial body. D. a branded horse. **Answer: B — a crop-rate/rate-setting element in assessment practice.** **Explanation:** Dastur belongs to rate formation. The rank and horse choices test whether vocabulary has been put in the wrong basket.

Q27. The land categories are analytically useful because they

A. measure the number of cavalymen. B. name three provincial offices. C. track regular cultivation and lengths of fallow, not caste hierarchy. D. fix a cash salary. **Answer: C — track regular cultivation and lengths of fallow, not caste hierarchy.** **Explanation:** Cultivation history is the discriminating idea. Cavalry and salary relate to mansabdari rather than land-use categories.

Q28. Polaj should not be defined simply as

A. land regularly cultivated. B. a category used with other fallow labels. C. a revenue-relevant land-use description. D. the most fertile land in every context, because the categories concern cultivation frequency. **Answer: D — the most fertile land in every context, because the categories concern cultivation frequency.** **Explanation:** The exclusion is the fertility-only simplification. Regular cultivation is the safer description.

Q29. A collector using a fixed share of the harvested crop is closest to

A. batai or ghalla-bakhshi. B. nasaq. C. dahsala. D. chehra. **Answer: A — batai or ghalla-bakhshi.** **Explanation:** Crop division identifies batai. Nasaq relies on estimate from prior demand, while chehra records soldiers.

Q30. A field measured and then assessed through appraisal of standing crop illustrates

A. khalisa. B. kankut. C. sawar. D. inam. **Answer: B — kankut.** **Explanation:** Measurement plus estimate is the exact kankut discriminator. Khalisa and inam are fiscal destinations/grants, not assessment techniques.

Q31. An estimate based substantially on earlier demand rather than fresh full survey illustrates

A. zabti. B. dagh. C. nasaq. D. pargana. **Answer: C — nasaq.** **Explanation:** Nasaq uses earlier assessment/payment as an important base. Zabt foregrounds measurement, and dagh concerns horses.

Q32. Which formulation best states the geographic limit of zabt?

A. It was applied identically throughout all India. B. It operated only inside imperial karkhanas. C. It excluded Malwa and Gujarat by definition. D. It had identified core zones but did not erase alternative methods in difficult or varied regions. **Answer: D — It had identified core zones but did not erase alternative methods in difficult or varied regions.** **Explanation:** Uneven extension is the source-grounded conclusion. The all-India option is the standard universal-zabt trap.

Q33. Cash assessment should be interpreted as

A. a stimulus to monetisation and market linkage, qualified by regional unevenness. B. proof that all agrarian exchange became commercial. C. proof that grain arrangements vanished. D. a definition of village autonomy.

Answer: A — a stimulus to monetisation and market linkage, qualified by regional unevenness. **Explanation:** The trend is real but not total. The complete-commercialisation option converts a tendency into an unsupported universal conclusion.

Q34. Why do historians separate jama from hasil?

A. It separates two types of cavalry. B. The distinction tests whether an assessed fiscal claim was actually realised. C. It separates two courts of law. D. It separates two kinds of horse brand. **Answer: B — The distinction tests whether an assessed fiscal claim was actually realised.** **Explanation:** The terms let an answer see fiscal shortfall. Military, court and branding alternatives misplace a fiscal distinction.

Q35. A zamindar's significance for state capacity lies partly in

A. his automatic right to a mansab. B. his identity as a central diwan. C. local mediation, claims and social/armed resources that could assist or constrain collection. D. his exemption from every revenue claim. **Answer: C — local mediation, claims and social/armed resources that could assist or constrain collection.** **Explanation:** Mediation makes zamindars both resource and limit. The diwan and automatic-mansab options collapse local and central roles.

Q36. The most precise iqta-jagir comparison begins by noting

A. both were identical private property titles. B. Akbar invented the first of them. C. neither had any fiscal connection. D. both linked revenue assignments to service while differing in context, audit, tenure and systematisation. **Answer: D — both linked revenue assignments to service while differing in context, audit, tenure and systematisation.** **Explanation:** Controlled similarity is correct. Identity and first-invention claims both discard historical differentiation.

Q37. Sher Shah's relevance to Akbar's revenue history is that

A. his precedents informed later refinement without making Akbar's system a mere copy. B. he created zat-sawar in 1595-96. C. he abolished measurement permanently. D. he wrote Ain-i-Akbari. **Answer: A — his precedents informed later refinement without making Akbar's system a mere copy.** **Explanation:** Precedent plus adaptation is the point. Zat-sawar and Ain belong to Akbar's later system and Abu'l Fazl's project.

Q38. Which is a structural limitation rather than a denial of Akbar's capacity?

A. The existence of any rank hierarchy. B. The gap between nominal contingents and actual musters. C. The use of all records. D. The division into subas. **Answer: B — The gap between nominal contingents and actual musters.**
Explanation: Paper-versus-actual capacity qualifies inspection. The other options are core instruments of systematisation, not limits in themselves.

Q39. Ain-i-Akbari is strongest when used for

A. a complete modern census of every locality. B. an unmediated peasant diary. C. administrative categories, official norms and the imperial vision of order. D. an official UPSC answer key. **Answer: C — administrative categories, official norms and the imperial vision of order.**
Explanation: Genre makes the Ain rich for official repertoire and weak for universal practice. The census claim is the closest over-reading.

Q40. Abu'l Fazl's praise most directly requires the historian to

A. discard every administrative category he reports. B. treat Badauni as automatically neutral. C. ignore farmans and records. D. separate imperial ideology from an automatic proof of implementation. **Answer: D — separate imperial ideology from an automatic proof of implementation.**
Explanation: Patronage calls for qualification, not wholesale rejection. Badauni also has a positional lens and cannot be automatic correction.

Q41. Badauni is most responsibly used as

A. a situated, often hostile courtly voice that can illuminate dissent but needs criticism. B. a statistically complete fiscal survey. C. the author of the Ain-i-Akbari. D. a proof that all regulations failed. **Answer: A — a situated, often hostile courtly voice that can illuminate dissent but needs criticism.**
Explanation: A hostile voice offers a different perspective, not a universal verdict. The authorship option confuses him with Abu'l Fazl.

Q42. Why are farmans, coins and records valuable alongside chronicles?

A. They eliminate all source bias. B. They can corroborate particular orders, transactions or claims through distinct evidentiary traces. C. They make local variation irrelevant. D. They prove every norm was universally enforced.
Answer: B — They can corroborate particular orders, transactions or claims through distinct evidentiary traces.
Explanation: Complementary genres can test specific claims, but none removes context or proves universal implementation.

Q43. Which modern comparison stays within a safe boundary?

A. Calling jagir a digital property title. B. Calling suba a constitutionally sovereign state. C. Using an audit analogy for verification while denying equivalence to modern democratic accountability. D. Calling mansab an open competitive civil-service exam. **Answer: C — Using an audit analogy for verification while denying equivalence to modern democratic accountability.**
Explanation: A narrow functional analogy is allowed. The other choices import legal and political equivalences that the evidence does not support.

Q44. The strongest overall verdict on Akbar's state capacity is that it

A. was either perfectly centralised or wholly fictitious. B. abolished local power completely. C. operated without coercion or market risk. D. systematised rank, records, revenue and oversight while remaining personal, hierarchical and uneven in reach. **Answer: D — systematised rank, records, revenue and oversight while remaining personal, hierarchical and uneven in reach.**
Explanation: The balanced verdict holds achievement and limit together. The perfect-or-fictitious choice creates the false binary the topic rejects.

Remedial MCQs — 16 questions (A -> B -> C -> D repeated four times)

Q1. A learner says, “Dahsala and zabt are identical.” What is the best correction?

A. Zabt is measurement-based assessment; dahsala is an averaging device used in assessment. B. Both are names for crop sharing. C. Dahsala is only a horse-inspection measure. D. Zabt means a permanent ten-year tenure.

Answer: A — Zabt is measurement-based assessment; dahsala is an averaging device used in assessment.

Explanation: The two terms are connected but not identical. The nearest error is treating ten-year averaging as an immutable settlement.

Q2. What does the 'ten' in dahsala most safely indicate?

A. A ten-year transfer ban on jagirdars. B. A ten-year data average of produce and prices. C. Ten fixed annual crop shares. D. Ten ranks within mansabdari. **Answer: B — A ten-year data average of produce and prices.**

Explanation: The correct choice identifies the calculation. The transfer-ban distractor mistakes a fiscal data period for personnel policy.

Q3. Which pairing is correct?

A. Zat—crop share; sawar—cash rate. B. Zat—provincial governor; sawar—diwan. C. Zat—personal status/pay; sawar—cavalry obligation. D. Zat—horse brand; sawar—soldier roll. **Answer: C — Zat—personal status/pay; sawar—cavalry obligation.**

Explanation: The pair separates two dimensions of mansab. Horse brand and soldier roll describe dagh and chehra, not zat and sawar.

Q4. Why is “jagir equals land ownership” unsound?

A. Jagirs were village panchayats. B. Jagirs were always cash salaries only. C. Jagirs were judicial courts. D. It mistakes a state revenue assignment for private title. **Answer: D — It mistakes a state revenue assignment for private title.** **Explanation:** The revenue-right/title distinction is decisive. Cash salary is a related payment mode, but it does not define jagir.

Q5. Which contrast best distinguishes jagirdar from zamindar?

A. Jagirdar was generally a transferable imperial assignee; zamindar held local claims and mediation power. B. Jagirdar was always a peasant; zamindar always an emperor. C. They were identical labels for mir bakhshi. D. Zamindar was a rank above 7000. **Answer: A — Jagirdar was generally a transferable imperial assignee; zamindar held local claims and mediation power.**

Explanation: The distinction is relationship to revenue and locality. Both had power, but not the same institutional position.

Q6. Which ascending order prevents the common hierarchy error?

A. suba -> pargana -> sarkar. B. pargana -> sarkar -> suba. C. sarkar -> suba -> pargana. D. village -> suba -> sarkar.

Answer: B — pargana -> sarkar -> suba. **Explanation:** Pargana, sarkar and suba are the progressively larger units. The closest error moves pargana above sarkar.

Q7. Which statement prevents a diwan/mir bakhshi mix-up?

A. Diwan branded horses and mir bakhshi measured fields. B. Diwan was only a village clerk. C. Diwan handled fiscal accounts; mir bakhshi handled rank, presentation and muster records. D. Mir bakhshi was a hereditary zamindar.

Answer: C — Diwan handled fiscal accounts; mir bakhshi handled rank, presentation and muster records.

Explanation: Functional specialisation is the discriminator. Branding and measuring are techniques, not the core division of these offices.

Q8. Why is 'Todar Mal alone created dahsala' weak?

A. Todar Mal never worked in revenue. B. Only Bairam Khan set rates. C. No records were used in the system. D. Revenue reform involved Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur, alongside evolving experiments.

Answer: D — Revenue reform involved Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur, alongside evolving experiments. **Explanation:** The correction is collective institutional work, not erasing Todar Mal. The Bairam option wrongly turns a regent into fiscal architect.

Q9. What refutes a universal-zabt claim?

A. Batai, kankut and nasaq remained alternatives where terrain, crop or records made fresh measurement unsuitable. B. All alternatives were religious grants. C. Zabt applied only to military camps. D. Dahsala prohibited local estimation.

Answer: A — Batai, kankut and nasaq remained alternatives where terrain, crop or records made fresh measurement unsuitable. **Explanation:** Multiple methods reveal uneven capacity. The closest wrong option imagines dahsala legally barred estimation.

Q10. Which sequence correctly maps the cultivation categories from more regular to long uncultivated use?

A. banjar -> chachar -> polaj -> parati. B. polaj -> parati/parauti -> chachar -> banjar. C. polaj -> chachar -> parati -> banjar. D. parati -> polaj -> banjar -> chachar. **Answer: B — polaj -> parati/parauti -> chachar -> banjar.**

Explanation: The discriminator is cultivation/fallow history. The close distractor swaps parati and chachar, confusing shorter and longer fallow.

Q11. Which trio is correctly matched?

A. Batai—horse brand; kankut—soldier roll; nasaq—jagir. B. Batai—ten-year average; kankut—cash title; nasaq—suba. C. Batai—crop share; kankut—measurement plus estimate; nasaq—previous-demand estimate. D. Batai—provincial check; kankut—rank; nasaq—grant. **Answer: C — Batai—crop share; kankut—measurement plus estimate; nasaq—previous-demand estimate.**

Explanation: All three are revenue methods with distinct techniques. The second option mixes revenue terms with military and territorial vocabulary.

Q12. Which statement preserves the dagh/chehra lineage?

A. Akbar invented both without precedent. B. The controls first appeared after Aurangzeb. C. Sher Shah replaced them with land categories. D. Alauddin used the controls, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them in Mughal practice. **Answer: D — Alauddin used the controls, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them in Mughal practice.** **Explanation:** Continuity with adaptation is the key. The invention option removes the Sultanate/Sur background.

Q13. Which analogy is acceptable only with an explicit boundary?

A. A payroll audit can clarify verification, but mansabdari was not a modern merit civil service. B. A suba was exactly a federal state. C. A jagir was exactly a digital property title. D. A qazi was an elected constitutional judge. **Answer: A — A payroll audit can clarify verification, but mansabdari was not a modern merit civil service.** **Explanation:** The limited functional analogy is valid; the other three project modern legal-political categories into a ruler-centred empire.

Q14. What does 'ruler-centred checks' mean?

A. Courts could depose the emperor through judicial review. B. Offices checked concentration through differentiated roles while the emperor retained appointment and final authority. C. The diwan was elected by villages. D. Subas had constitutionally guaranteed autonomy. **Answer: B — Offices checked concentration through differentiated roles while the emperor retained appointment and final authority.** **Explanation:** The phrase combines differentiation with monarchical primacy. Judicial review and elected office are modern imports.

Q15. Which statement best handles cash in the revenue system?

A. Every peasant everywhere paid only coin. B. Cash demand abolished local intermediaries. C. Cash assessment encouraged monetisation, but regional variation and kind arrangements qualify claims of complete commercialisation. D. Currency had no relation to markets. **Answer: C — Cash assessment encouraged monetisation, but regional variation and kind arrangements qualify claims of complete commercialisation.** **Explanation:** The answer holds trend and limitation together. The all-coin option turns an uneven fiscal tendency into a universal fact.

Q16. Why is Ain-i-Akbari not a modern census?

A. It contains no administrative information. B. It was written by Badauni as a hostile memoir. C. It is an official answer key. D. It records administrative ideals and compiled figures within an imperial project, requiring norm-versus-practice caution. **Answer: D — It records administrative ideals and compiled figures within an imperial project, requiring norm-versus-practice caution.** **Explanation:** Its value is real but bounded by genre and patronage. The Badauni option confuses contrasting source voices.

Ten examiner-grade solved Mains answers

Mains 1. [10 marks | 150 words] Explain the nature of checks and balances in Akbar's central administration.

Directive alignment: Explain the mechanism, not a modern constitutional doctrine.

Introduction. Akbar differentiated offices to prevent concentration of effective power, but the arrangement remained a personal monarchy in which appointment and final arbitration lay with the emperor.

Claim—evidence—analysis. The Bairam Khan regency supplied the key political lesson: after a powerful *wakil* had overshadowed the young ruler, the office retained prestige but was reduced in effective power. This prevented a permanent all-powerful wazir. Fiscal and military functions were then differentiated. The **diwan** scrutinised income, expenditure, khalisa, jagir and inam accounts, while the **mir bakhshi** dealt with mansab presentation, muster-related records and personnel. Their different information streams made unilateral capture harder. The **mir saman** managed household/karkhana resources, and sadr-qazi functions covered grants and justice, adding specialised rather than undifferentiated authority.

Qualification. These were not autonomous ministries, an elected cabinet or judicial review. Overlap, patronage and imperial intervention remained normal; expertise amplified the sovereign rather than limiting him constitutionally.

Conclusion. Akbar's checks were therefore administrative and ruler-centred: they disciplined office-holders and improved information while preserving personal monarchy.

Why this earns marks: It defines the limited sense of “checks,” uses Bairam Khan plus named offices as evidence, explains their mechanism, and explicitly rejects anachronism.

Mains 2. [15 marks | 200 words] Discuss the central and provincial government under Akbar. How far did its structure restrain provincial autonomy?

Directive alignment: Cover both levels and assess—not merely list—the restraint.

Introduction. Akbar combined central specialisation with provincial replication, seeking reliable revenue, service and information across an expanding empire.

Central design. The emperor remained the source of appointment, justice, military command and patronage. The diwan's accounts and the mir bakhshi's mansab/muster records separated fiscal from personnel-military information; the mir saman's household-karkhana charge made material supply visible; sadr-qazi functions connected grants and adjudication. The reduced post-Bairam *wakil* illustrates deliberate avoidance of one over-mighty coordinator.

Provincial design. In 1580, the twelve-subas arrangement placed a **subadar** beside a provincial diwan, bakhshi, sadr-qazi and reporting personnel. The same principle operated below: suba -> sarkar -> pargana -> village. Amils, qanungos, treasurers and clerks supplied fiscal records; faujdars served coercive/order functions but their jurisdiction was not mechanically coterminous with every sarkar.

Assessment. Central appointment, differentiated functions and cross-reporting restrained a governor from monopolising revenue and force. Yet distance, campaign conditions, local alliances and the subadar's practical strength could weaken paper checks. Village and zamindari intermediaries also mediated reach.

Conclusion. The structure limited provincial autonomy more effectively than a single governor-centred chain, but it did so by imperial supervision, not federal or constitutional decentralisation.

Why this earns marks: It joins the two scales, dates the twelve-subas reform, names institutions and produces a qualified judgment about real rather than diagrammatic control.

Mains 3. [15 marks | 200 words] Examine mansabdari as both an elite-integration device and a military organisation.

Directive alignment: Treat both functions as mutually connected, not two separate lists.

Introduction. Mansabdari was a graded imperial service hierarchy in which a mansab fixed relative status, remuneration and service expectation; its strength was to make political incorporation and military obligation speak the same language.

Elite integration. Ranks beginning at 10 and reaching high grades such as 5000 (with exceptional 7000 ranks under Akbar) ordered a composite elite of Turanis, Iranis, Indian Muslims, Rajputs, Afghans and other entrants. Promotion, demotion, court honour, cash and jagir remuneration connected privilege to the emperor. This reduced the need to treat each aristocratic group as an autonomous territorial power, while family advantage and hierarchy remained.

Military organisation. A mansab was not only ceremonial. The later **zat-sawar** distinction (1595-96) separated personal status/pay from cavalry obligation, and the mir bakhshi's presentation and muster records tied rank to personnel. Dagh and chehra helped test horses and men against paper claims. Jagir assignments could finance service without converting the assignee into landowner.

Qualification. Actual contingents could fall short, inspections invited resistance or harassment, and jagir transfer encouraged dependence while creating short-term incentives. The system was neither hereditary feudalism nor a modern merit service.

Conclusion. Mansabdari integrated elites precisely because its honour, pay and military claims were interlocked under imperial review.

Why this earns marks: It answers both halves through one causal mechanism and anchors analysis in composite recruitment, 1595-96, dagh/chehra and jagir qualification.

Mains 4. [10 marks | 150 words] Explain the significance and limits of the zat-sawar distinction and verification devices under Akbar.

Directive alignment: Explain late rank refinement and assess verification, not merely define terms.

Introduction. The dual rank emerged in Akbar's fortieth regnal year, **1595-96**, showing that mansabdari evolved through clarification rather than beginning as a finished blueprint.

Significance. **Zat** denoted personal rank, courtly status and related pay; **sawar** identified cavalry obligation. Separating them made it easier to express a noble's precedence without assuming that personal eminence exactly equalled contingent size. The mir bakhshi's presentation and muster role linked the formula to record-making.

Verification. Dagh (horse branding) and chehra (descriptive rolls) sought to expose fictitious horses, substituted mounts and nominal soldiers. Their line of provenance matters: Alauddin Khalji used such controls, Sher Shah revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them in the Mughal framework; Akbar's dagh measure is placed in 1573-74.

Limits. Inspection was costly, nobles resisted intrusive checking, officials could harass, and a paper rank never guaranteed a full actual contingent. Technical "class" labels should not replace the basic distinction.

Conclusion. Together they sharpened imperial knowledge of service, but supplied partial control rather than a modern audited army.

Why this earns marks: It gets chronology and provenance right, connects terminology to institutional purpose, and names operational limits.

Mains 5. [15 marks | 200 words] Analyse the relationship between mansab, jagir and imperial dependence under Akbar.

Directive alignment: Explain a relationship and its tension; do not reduce jagir to ownership.

Introduction. A mansab set rank, remuneration and obligation; a jagir was often the revenue assignment through which the state met that remuneration. The connection bound service to imperial fiscal resources.

Mechanism. A graded mansab established a noble's salary claim and expected service. Cash payment was possible, but a jagir commonly assigned the right to collect specified state revenue. The diwan's scrutiny of khalisa, jagir and inam accounts and the language of **jama** versus **hasil** matter because a nominal assessment was not identical with actual receipt. Thus the assignment was calculated fiscal support, not a free-standing landed estate.

Dependence. Appointment, transfer, promotion, demotion and reassignment kept the mansabdar dependent on imperial favour and curtailed stable territorial roots. The contrast with a **zamindar** is essential: a jagirdar was generally a transferable assignee; a zamindar had local claims, mediation capacity and social/armed power.

Tension. Transfers could inhibit provincial independence yet make quick extraction attractive, especially if jama exceeded hasil. These are structural seeds later magnified in seventeenth-century pressure; they should not be inflated into an Akbar-era collapse.

Conclusion. Mansab-jagir linkage was an ingenious salary-and-control arrangement whose very flexibility produced a recurrent tension between central dependence and local extraction.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes ownership from assignment, uses jama/hasil and jagirdar/zamindar precisely, then projects later consequences only with a time boundary.

Mains 6. [20 marks | 250 words] Explain the working of the dahsala system. Was it a uniform and permanent settlement?

Directive alignment: Explain process, then test two false assumptions—uniformity and permanence.

Introduction. Dahsala, implemented in **1580**, was a fiscal technique that used a ten-year average of produce and prices to make assessment more predictable; it was neither synonymous with every zabt operation nor a permanent ten-year settlement.

Working. Akbar's revenue experiments followed Sur precedents but found central price schedules too blunt for local variation. The team of **Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur** developed more usable local productivity/price circles. Under measurement-based **zabti**, fields could be measured with a jarib described as bamboo linked by iron rings. Dastur/crop-rate machinery combined area, yield and price knowledge. Dahsala averaged a decade's produce and prices; the theoretical state share was one-third of average produce, converted into cash. It gave both official and payer a more intelligible claim, while serving military and household finance.

Why not permanent. "Ten" identifies the data series, not a fixed decade-long tenure or unalterable demand. Crop failure, price conditions and later revision make a permanent- settlement analogy false. Remission and, where available, assistance could support cultivation, but they did not abolish pressure, cesses, transport costs or coercive collection.

Why not uniform. Zabti/dahsala is safely associated with zones from Lahore to Allahabad and with Malwa and Gujarat; it should not be made pan-Indian. Batai/ghalla-bakhshi, kankut and nasaq persisted where crop, terrain, staff and records made other methods more practical. Bengal, Sindh, Kashmir and difficult tracts require this capacity qualification.

Conclusion. Dahsala was sophisticated fiscal information technology—measurement, averaging, price conversion and record—not a universal, permanent or peasant-welfare-only settlement.

Why this earns marks: It gives a full mechanism, names the reform team and instrument, distinguishes terms, and directly disposes of both misconceptions with geographic evidence.

Mains 7. [20 marks | 250 words] Compare Akbar's revenue methods and assess their fiscal reach and limits.

Directive alignment: Compare methods by technique and suitability, then judge reach.

Introduction. Akbar's revenue administration was a repertoire rather than a single formula: its methods balanced information, local conditions and fiscal demand with uneven success.

Methods. **Zabti** used measured area and rates; when combined with the **dahsala** average of produce and prices, it supported cash assessment. **Batai/ghalla-bakhshi** divided crop in a fixed proportion, fitting circumstances where realised output mattered but requiring supervision and division. **Kankut** combined field measurement with inspection/appraisal of standing crop, while **nasaq** substantially relied on prior payment/assessment and estimate, avoiding a full fresh survey. **Polaj**, **parati/parauti**, **chachar** and **banjar** helped classify cultivation/fallow history; they should not be confused with a simple fertility scale.

Fiscal reach. Measurement, **jarib** standardisation, local **dastur** and provincial/central diwan records increased the state's ability to formulate a predictable claim. Cash demand connected assessment to coin and markets, and the system is associated with Lahore-to- Allahabad, Malwa and Gujarat. It financed court, campaign, service and household and checked officials through documentation.

Limits. A paper **jama** could differ from realised **hasil**. **Zabt** was not universal: difficult tracts, regional price/productivity variation and administrative capacity kept alternatives alive. Zamindars and village intermediaries mediated local reach; cesses, price risks, transport and coercive collection complicate welfare claims. Remission did not erase extraction.

Conclusion. The multiplicity of methods is not evidence of failure; it is evidence of pragmatic adaptation. It also marks the boundary of a state whose record capacity remained uneven.

Why this earns marks: It compares all four methods accurately, uses land categories and **jama/hasil**, and converts variation into an analytical judgment rather than a fact list.

Mains 8. [15 marks | 200 words] Assess the place of zamindars and local intermediaries in Akbar's revenue administration.

Directive alignment: Assess agency and constraint; avoid both disappearance and autonomy myths.

Introduction. Akbar's fiscal system increased official measurement and record-making, but it worked through rather than around local intermediaries.

Roles. At village and pargana levels, **muqaddams/patels**, **patwaris**, **chaudhuris**, **qanungos**, **amils**, **treasurers** and **clerks** supplied local knowledge, custody and records. Zamindars were local landed claimants and mediators in collection, with social authority and at times armed following. Their location between cultivator and state made them indispensable for information, mobilisation and negotiation.

Official framework. **Zabti** measurement, **jarib**, **dastur** and the provincial diwan sought to make the claim more legible to the centre. The chain—cultivator/local intermediary -> **amil** and records -> provincial diwan -> central diwan—shows a layered rather than direct relationship. The difference between **jama** and **hasil** also reveals why nominal official demand depended on practical realisation.

Qualification. A zamindar was not simply a British landlord projected backward, nor the same as a transferable **jagirdar**. Nor should customary autonomy be romanticised: state demand, coercion and officials mattered. In some contexts local bargaining could constrain implementation; in others official pressure was acute.

Conclusion. Local intermediaries were a constitutive part of Mughal state capacity and a limit upon its uniformity, not a residue outside the state.

Why this earns marks: It locates actors in a revenue chain, distinguishes zamindar from **jagirdar**, and presents intermediary power as both resource and limit.

Mains 9. [20 marks | 250 words] Trace continuity and change from Sultanate and Sur practices to Akbar's administration.

Directive alignment: Trace a process across periods while avoiding “first invention” and mechanical-copy claims.

Introduction. Akbar's state was an exercise in selective inheritance: Sultanate and Sur techniques supplied administrative repertoires, while imperial expansion required greater specialisation, ranking and fiscal coordination.

Continuities. The Sultanate had revenue assignment through iqta and military/fiscal controls; the Sur regime is associated with measurement, roads, coins and administrative experimentation. Dagh and chehra offer the clearest continuity line: **Alauddin Khalji** introduced/used horse branding and descriptive rolls; **Sher Shah** revived/adapted them; **Akbar** systematised/reintroduced them in a Mughal framework. This evidence defeats an Akbar-first claim.

Changes under Akbar. The post-Bairam reduction of wakil power, stronger diwan specialisation and mir bakhshi's mansab/muster role created a more articulated central arrangement. In 1580, twelve subas replicated differentiated offices and central appointment. Mansabdari made status, remuneration and service part of one graded hierarchy and integrated Turani, Irani, Indian Muslim, Rajput, Afghan and other elites. Revenue experiments developed into measurement-based zabti and dahsala's ten-year produce-price averaging, associated with Muzaffar Khan, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur.

Qualification. Iqta and jagir were both revenue assignments linked to service but not interchangeable: compare tenure, audit, scale and their relation to rank. Akbar's system did not erase local intermediaries or make assessment universal. Batai, kankut and nasaq stayed necessary.

Conclusion. Continuity supplied techniques; Akbar's distinctive achievement was their coordinated use in ruler-centred systems of office, information, rank and fiscal calculation.

Why this earns marks: It traces rather than lists, gives the exact dagh/chehra provenance, compares iqta/jagir cautiously and explains what systematisation changed.

Mains 10. [20 marks | 250 words] How should Ain-i-Akbari be used to evaluate Akbar's state capacity? Give a balanced verdict.

Directive alignment: Evaluate a source as evidence and use it to reach—not assume—a verdict on state capacity.

Introduction. The *Ain-i-Akbari*, part of Abu'l Fazl's Akbarnama project, is indispensable for administrative vocabulary, norms and compiled data, but it is an imperial compendium and cannot be read as a modern census or a transparent record of universal practice.

What it reveals. Its categories illuminate the state imagined and claimed by Akbar's court: mansab rank, office, suba organisation, revenue terminology, household resources and fiscal order. Read alongside details such as the diwan's accounts, mir bakhshi's personnel records, dahsala calculation and provincial differentiation, it supports an argument for considerable early modern state capacity: rulers sought legible fields, ranked service, inspected horses and collected reports.

Source criticism. Abu'l Fazl wrote within a patronage relationship and presented an ideal imperial order; precision of figures does not by itself prove implementation in every village. Norm must be distinguished from practice, and administrative efficiency from justice. **Badauni** can reveal hostile/sectarian courtly reaction when relevant, but his opposition is not a neutral social survey. Farmans, surviving revenue records, coins, inscriptions and later historians can corroborate particular orders, transactions, circulation or local variation, each with survival and genre limits.

Balanced state-capacity verdict. Akbar's system linked records, specialised offices, mansab, inspection, provincial replication and fiscal calculation more systematically than a loose personal retinue. Yet reach was uneven: alternatives to zabt, local zamindars, jama-hasil gaps, inspection evasion and coercive collection demonstrate limits. Capacity was real precisely because the court tried to manage these problems, not because its normative text made them disappear.

Conclusion. Use the Ain as a rich map of imperial administrative aspiration and repertoire, triangulated against other evidence; then a qualified, not triumphalist, account of Mughal state capacity follows.

Why this earns marks: It makes source criticism operational, names complementary evidence, and turns “capacity” into mechanisms and limitations rather than praise of figures.